

The seabed

Unlike the deep ocean floor, the seabeds of shallow coastal seas are lit up and warmed by sunlight. This allows many forms of life to flourish in large numbers, especially in shallower parts of the sea where the light level is higher. Different types of seabed give the animals a wide variety of places to live.

RAGGED ROCKS

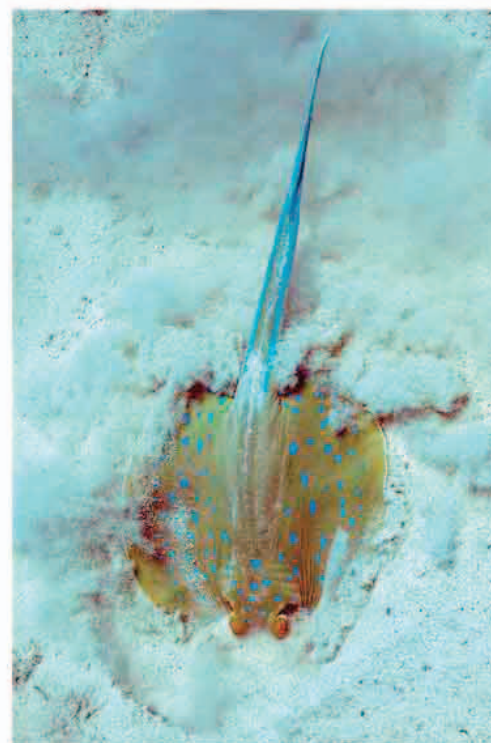
In places, the hard bedrock of the seabed is exposed to form rocky reefs. These are often teeming with marine life—seaweeds, sponges, sea squirts, and many types of shellfish that are attached to the rocky reefs. The ragged and tumbled rocks are also full of holes that make safe refuges for seafloor animals, including eels, crabs, lobsters, and octopuses.



SHIFTING SANDS

Many seabeds are covered with deep layers of sand and other soft sediments. Most of this is the result of thousands of years of coastal erosion, but a lot is carried out to sea by rivers. Although the sand looks barren, it is full of burrowing worms and clams that are hunted by seafloor animals.

▲ **RIBBON-TAILED STINGRAY**
The mouth of this tropical stingray is underneath its body so it can easily scoop up prey hidden in the sand.



SHIPWRECKS

Many of the shifting sandbanks and rocky reefs of coastal seas lie just below the surface. Before the days of accurate charts and satellite navigation, they caused many shipwrecks. As a result, shallow seabeds are littered with the remains of ships, some dating back more than a thousand years. These wrecks now provide perfect homes for marine life.

